

[CH1] When Computers were People

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- Computer originally meant "One who computes".
 - It was an occupation, not a machine
- Although the modern computer can work with numbers, it is most often used in order to store information as a clerk would.

Tables

- Tables started being produced as a way to speed up calculations in various different fields (trigonometric tables for angles, star tables for astronomers, logarithmic tables for mathematicians, etc etc)

The Nautical Almanac

- A set of navigation tables that has been released every year without fail in the United Kingdom since the 18th century

Baron de Prony

- De Prony had to, simultaneously, create new tables for several purposes and, to better manage the workload, turned his operation into a table-making "factory" divided into 3 sections

Charles Babbage

- British mathematician and economist, son of a London banker
- Studied mathematics at Trinity College, Cambridge University, but was dismayed at the state of British mathematics
- He established the Analytical Society together with 2 classmates to revamp British mathematics
- He was a talented propagandist
- He was inspired by the French Baron de Prony's table making technique
- In the 30 years since Prony's project, new machines had surfaced in factories, so Babbage decided to create a table-making machine: the Difference Engine. It consisted of a set of adding mechanisms to do the calculations, as well as a printing system